

welcoming her village mate and idol, Vinesh Phogat, following her return from the Paris Olympics.

Pulkit Kandola, a Jind native and Asian silver medallist in 2022, displayed impressive fitness and skill, scoring 36 points while conceding just six in five bouts. Returning to international competition after a two-year recovery from knee surgery, Pulkit's success is a testament to her father's support and belief in her potential on the global stage.

Kajal, from Lath village in Sonipat district, drew inspiration from her wrestler relative, Krishan. An Asian U-15 champion in 2022 and an U-17 champion the following year, Kajal overcame formidable opponents, including Ulyana Lapanik of Russia, Ako Uchiyama of Japan, and Oleksandra Rybak of Ukraine [in the final], to achieve victory.

Mansi, the daughter of a wrestling couple, embraced the sport naturally at her family's *akhara* in Jind. She quickly distinguished herself, securing gold medals at national competitions before becoming the Asian champion in the 69kg category and the U-17 World champion in her breakthrough season this year.

Known for her aggressive style, Mansi pinned three of her opponents and defeated the gold and silver medallists from the previous year to claim the title with impressive flair.

"At any level, a World Championships is always tough. Some of our girls defeated accomplished wrestlers at this level. For the next two Olympics, we have a good batch of women wrestlers who can go on to qualify in all weight categories and do well," said coach Jai Bhagwan, who accompanied the wrestlers.

Asked about his daughter Mansi, Jai said, "Her biggest strength is her confidence. I was apprehensive ahead of her bout against the world champion, but she performed much better than I expected and dominated. She has won two school national golds, one national gold, an Asian gold, and a Worlds gold in about a year's time."



Filled with pride: Mansi Lather celebrating her 73kg title win with father, Jai Bhagwan. Mansi was leading 5-0 in her final against Hanna Pirskeya before pinning her opponent to win by fall. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Jai also praised Bala, Shrutika and Muskan (a multiple World U-17 medallist). "The girls who won silver and bronze are equally good, and they could have landed gold as well. In sports, sometimes it is not your day. They are all at the same level."

Shilpi, a former wrestler making her debut as a coach on an international assignment, mentioned that the coaching staff worked hard to motivate the girls. "We worked on keeping the wrestlers relaxed and motivated and keeping them insulated from any negative thoughts.

They were disciplined, dedicated and focused. Their confidence level

was up. Someone like Mansi has conceded just two points in all her bouts, while Neha defeated her Japanese opponent 10-0," said Shilpi, the wife of former World Championships bronze medallist Narsingh Yadav.

"Their resilience was something. Whenever anyone conceded a point, we asked her to be relaxed and fight back at the right time. Our girls had the stamina, so instead of being unnecessarily aggressive, they needed to focus and attack at the right time.

"Even when they were cutting weight prior to their bouts, we made sure that they should not feel it was